get into your fallout shelter. The principal effect of Kennedy's announcement was to increase public anxiety and bolster such enterprises as the Peace-O-Mind Shelter Company.[29]

Kennedy's rhetoric was intended to signal strength and to strengthen the resolve of NATO allies. It also repeated an important – and, for many, controversial – concession. Under the terms of the Potsdam agreement responsibility for all the people of Berlin lay with the four occupying powers. Kennedy however, explicitly stated that his concern was for the security of *West* Berlin. He had volunteered this in Vienna, much to the consternation of those, especially in the State Department, who saw it as an unwarranted retreat. For JFK, it was an expression of his pragmatism and his recognition of a *de facto* division of Europe that needed to be managed for the foreseeable future. The nations of the Warsaw Pact – including the German Democratic Republic – would remain in the Soviet orbit of influence; those in NATO – including the Federal Republic of Germany – would remain in the West. The idea ran counter to many of those in Europe – notably the West German Chancellor, Konrad Adenauer – who retained a vison of a united and Western-oriented Germany.

Kennedy's speech of 25 July also referred to West Berlin as an 'escape hatch' for those wishing to flee the communist East for the capitalist West. Between September 1949 and August 1961, some 2.7 million East Germans fled west, including many of the younger and better educated. For Walter Ulbricht's government in East Berlin, the outflow of workers – especially skilled workers – posed an increasingly serious threat to the East German economy. Ulbricht pressed his solution – to close the border with West Berlin – on Moscow. Nikita Khrushchev was conscious of how this would appear to world opinion, but was also aware that the drain of workers was 'creating a simply disastrous situation in the GDR'.[30] More than 150,00 refugees went west in the first six months of 1961.[31] By August 1961 the exodus was 10,000 per week.

On the night of Sunday, 13 August 1961 specially selected East German police units, backed by the East German National People's Army (NVA), in turn backed by Soviet troops, formed a human barrier to seal off West Berlin. By the morning, a huge logistical effort had created a barbed wire